Send in the clones

Clonaid is firmly in the eye of a storm after it revealed to the world the first successfully cloned human—the baby girl Eve. Born to an American couple, Eve raised eyebrows, both scientific and ethical. The cloning company was founded by Claude Vorilhon, who claims that a space alien visited him in 1973 to reveal that extraterrestrials had created all life on Earth through genetic engineering. Clonaid also announced the arrival of a future child, born to a lesbian couple.

Even as these announcements were made, visions of cloned humans and armies of cloned warriors flooded the ether. Scientists have dismissed popular myths about cloning, saying that images of an exact human replica or an army of clones is preposterous. The old nature versus nurture debate was brought to the table as those in the know explained how even identical twins have different personalities, due to the influence of the environment within which they are raised—regardless of fears felt, a clone would not be an exact replica of the person being cloned, but would be more akin to an identical twin one or two generations removed.

Gaming 101

The Guildhall, a game development course is set up in partnership with some of the biggest names in the gaming industry, including Richard Gray (Levelord) of Ritual Entertainment, id Software, Gearbox Software, Terminal Reality and Ensemble Studios in conjunction with the Southern Methodist University. The Guildhall promises to equip a chosen few with the essential skills to become serious game developers. It will hold intensive 18-month certificate courses with real world curriculum that has been set in consultation with gaming industry gurus. The faculty consists of selected Southern Methodist University professors and other experts in the digital games field. The course is rumoured to be tough and only 100 students will be chosen every six months. The course will cover gaming art production, level design and software development, with project work being all-important.

Apple laptop gets jumbo screen at MacWorld

Apple unleashed a new PowerBook at the MacWorld Expo. The occasion celebrates the second birthday of the acclaimed Titanium PowerBook family. The new Mac in town comes with a 17-inch screen, weighs a little over 3 kg and when closed, sits only an inch high. It can display a 1440x900 pixel resolution and comes powered with the 1 GHz PowerPC G4 processor, has 512 MB of RAM, a 60 GB hard disk and a DVD burner drive. It also features built-in Bluetooth, USB 1.1, FireWire 2 and the AirPort wireless networking technology. At the MacWorld Expo, Apple CEO Steve Jobs stated that Apple believes that notebooks and not desktops are the future of personal computing. Apple will also introduce a 12-inch portable that features an 867 MHz G4 and a 40 GB hard disk. It is targeted as a portable digital media studio, and it will be Bluetooth enabled, with 802.11g connectivity that promises faster speeds and better security. Both models are encased with super tough airplane-grade aluminium that is both light and durable. Both will ship starting March 2003.

IBM launches supercomputing

In an exciting new twist to supercomputing, Big Blue is now building supercomputer application hosting areas around the world, to offer customers the opportunity to use the grid. This is an example of the much-touted On Demand computing that was all set to revolutionise computing a few years ago. Under the program, IBM is building massive supercomputing grids based on hundreds of AIX-based pSeries servers and massive Linux-based xSeries server clusters. The first of these are located at Poughkeepsie, New York, with others to follow all over the world. The worldwide grid will be linked using the open source Globus grid software. Customers will get to migrate their server applications over to the IBM grid, saving enormous capital on upgrading and maintaining their existing setups. They will essentially pay only for the data processing capacity that they will utilise.

Figures for the service have not been released, but IBM maintains that pricing will depend on the quantum of processing capacity needed, the type of hardware needed, and how much work it has to put in to support the application. Currently, IBM is using hardware from its own stables, and industry analysts predict that Big Blue will consider working with supercomputing equipment from rival vendors once the On Demand initiative takes off.

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